

New Generation English B· Diagnostic Test

C2 (Proficiency Diagnostic) B· Listening

LISTENING

Seminar response: pushing back on the memory-history opposition

Script:

Let me push back briefly on a claim made in your last paper. You wrote that memory and history are opposed, and that the historian's task is to correct memory with evidence. I think this framing, while attractive, conceals more than it reveals.

Consider the following: in many historical contexts, communal memory has preserved patterns that documentary evidence missed entirely. Stories of pre-industrial epidemics, of unrecorded labour movements, of localised famines — these survived for generations in oral testimony before written sources caught up. Sometimes the documents were never produced, and sometimes they were produced selectively by people with their own interests. Memory, in those cases, was not the failed shadow of history; it was the only available record.

This does not mean that memory is reliable in the way documents can be. It is selective, suggestible and reshaped by present-day concerns. But the documentary record is also selective. The question, in any concrete case, is not which source is purer but which gives us the more honest reconstruction when combined with the other.

The danger of a strong opposition between memory and history is that it can seem to authorise the dismissal of communal recollection whenever it conflicts with paperwork. In practice, this dismissal has often served the powerful, because paperwork is more likely to survive when produced by the powerful. A history that systematically privileges documents will systematically under-record what was important to people who could not write, were not allowed to write, or wrote in forms we have not preserved.

So I would suggest a more dialectical formulation. History is what survives critical examination; memory is what a community lives by. The serious historian does not choose between them. The serious historian uses each to interrogate the other — and accepts, sometimes uncomfortably, that the most accurate account is produced not by adjudicating between them but by reading them together.

1. What is the speaker pushing back on?

- A) A claim that memory and history are opposed and that historians correct memory.**
- B) A new historical method.
- C) A particular textbook.

2. What kinds of episodes survived in oral testimony before written sources caught up?

- A) Wars only.
- B) Pre-industrial epidemics, unrecorded labour movements, localised famines.**
- C) Royal weddings.

3. Why were some documents never produced or selectively produced?

